Problem 2 (25 points). Semitic semi-Seminar on Cognates

(a)

a. ḥabl → ẖevel
b. baṭn → beten

Note that the choice of vowels won't be taken into consideration.

(b)

Hebrew:

ר	צ / ץ	ע	נ / ן	כ / ך	י	ט	ח	ד	ב	בּ	א
r	ts	ʿ (ayin)	n	k	y	t	ẖ	d	v	b	ʼ (alef)

Arabic:

ـط / ـطـ / طـ	ـر / ر	ـد / د	ـح / ـحـ / حـ	ـب / ـبـ / بـ	أ
ṭ	r	d	ḥ	b	ʼ (alif)

ـو / و	ـن / ـنـ / نـ	ـل / ـلـ / لـ	ـك / ـكـ / كـ	ض
w	n	l	k	ḍ

(c) 1 – a, 2 – f, 3 – h, 4 – e, 5 – j, 6 – b, 7 – i, 8 – c, 9 – g, 10 – d.

(d) ʻelef

Explanations:

In order to answer the questions, one must identify the words in the lists and pair them up with their cognates. One also has to come up with observations about the writing system and noticing patterns and phonological changes are crucial as well. To be able to start decoding, one must notice the first clue, that is "the first match (1. a.) is given for you" and the next paragraph containing the examples: **kalb → kelev** "*dog*"; **malik → melekh** "*king*"; **ʼarḍ → ʼerets** "*land, earth*"; **shams → shemesh** "<u>*sun*</u>"; **walad → yeled** "*child*". Out of words given, only one starts and ends identically in Hebrew. Thus, we have our first identified word-pair in transliteration: **shams → shemesh**, meaning "*sun*", matched with their original form **شمس** and **שמש**.

The next step is to find out which word belongs to which transliteration. We can assume that from the recurring pattern introduced above that the CeCeC belongs to Hebrew, while CaCC, CaCiC and CaCaC are the Arabic versions. It should now become evident that this writing system (for both languages) only notes consonants, since both words have only three characters. From "*sun*" we identified the letter 'm' in both scripts, and so we should look for something with an 'm'. There is only one other 'm', and we can match it with the pair **malik → melekh** "*king*" from the examples given.

At this point it should be clear that both scripts write from right to left. From here, we can identify the letter 'l' and the final form of 'kh'. Since there are 4 words with 'l', we need to use 'kh' as well. We might panic now because there is no other final 'kh' to find, but after a brief glimpse to the chart under task **(b)** we can identify the Hebrew 'k' which leads us to find the word with the roots k-l-v, and kelev "dog". Here we can pinpoint the corresponding 'b' (Arabic) and 'v' (Hebrew).

Consulting the charts in tasks **(b)** and **(c)**, and the eight examples given, we can decode every character step-by-step and find our matching pairs.